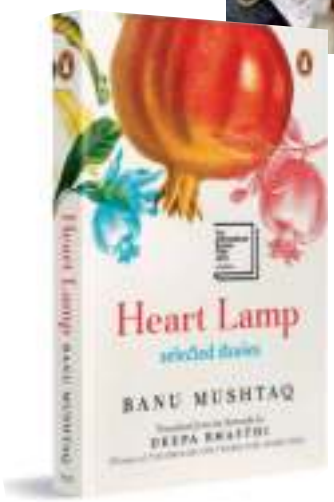
IN

In 'Stone Slabs for Shaista Mahal', the opening story from Banu Mushtaq's short story collection *Heart Lamp* (translated from Kannada by Deepa Bhasthi), there's a passage where the female narrator is struggling with how to introduce her husband to readers. "Mujahid is my home person. Oh. That sounds odd. A wife is usually the one who stays at home, so that makes her the home person. Perhaps then Mujahid is my office person. Che! I have made a mistake again. The office is not mine, after all. How else can I say this? If I use the term yajamana and call him owner, then I will have to be a servant, as if I am an animal or a dog."

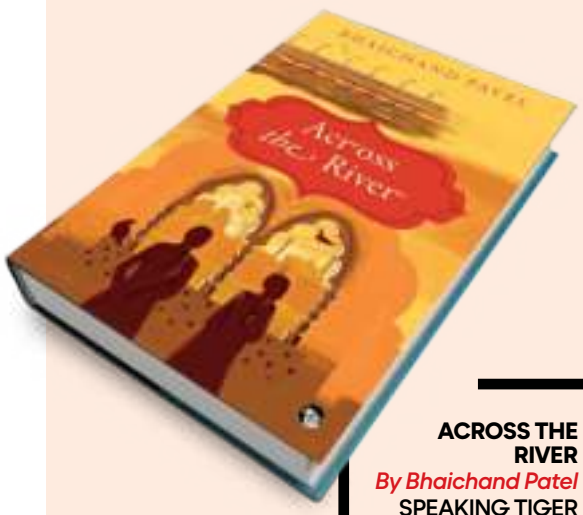
Heart Lamp, for which Mushtaq and Bhasthi have been shortlisted for the 2025 International Booker Prize, has several passages like this one, where a straight line is drawn between the mechanisms of language and the socio-political consequences of a patriarchal society. The 77-year-old Mushtaq, who has worked as a lawyer, an activist and a reporter previously, has been writing in



LITERARY PARTNERS Banu Mushtaq (left) with translator Deepa Bhasthi at the Bengaluru Litfest, 2024



HEART LAMP
Selected Stories
By Banu Mushtaq
Translated from the Kannada by Deepa Bhasthi
PENGUIN
₹399; 224 pages



ACROSS THE RIVER
By Bhaichand Patel
SPEAKING TIGER
₹499; 240 pages

BOOKS ▼

Love Across Lines

BHAICHAND PATEL'S NOVEL *ACROSS THE RIVER* EXPLORES THE TENSION BETWEEN TRADITION AND MODERNITY THROUGH THE LIVES OF TWO YOUNG WOMEN FROM OLD DELHI

Hindu-Muslim romances, once commonplace in Indian English literature, have all but vanished from its pages—even the latest notable exception, Geetanjali Shree's *Our City That Year*, is a 1990s Hindi novel recently translated into English. Because of this, the first act of Bhaichand Patel's *Across the River* feels really strong. The novel's twin protagonists. Seema Chaudhry and Madhu Gupta (a Muslim and a Hindu woman, respec-